TALK TWO

2 The Prophet of the Highest

"And thou, child, shalt be called the prophet of the Highest: for thou shalt go before the face of the Lord to prepare his ways."

LUKE 1:76

Zacharias stood alone at the golden altar of incense inside the temple. Outside, a crowd prayed and waited for him to finish. This elderly priest had been chosen for a duty he might have waited his whole life to perform. Then an angel appeared beside the altar. Luke says Zacharias was troubled and afraid. Whatever he had expected from the day, it was not this.

Serving at the altar of incense was a rare privilege. Zacharias was a priest from the hill country of Judea, one of thousands who took turns serving at the temple in twenty-four groups. During their service, lots were cast to assign duties. Only priests who had never offered incense could be chosen for the task, and many never had the opportunity. That day, the lot fell to Zacharias.

But the angel's message was about a hope much older than the day's assignment. Zacharias and his wife Elisabeth had no children, and both were old. Luke describes them as righteous people who kept God's commandments. Others may have assumed their childlessness meant they had done something wrong. Elisabeth later called it her "reproach among men." Luke tells us about their faithfulness before telling us about their sorrow so that we know their sorrow was not evidence that God had rejected them.

The angel announced that Elisabeth would have a son whose work would be to prepare people for the Lord. They were to name him John, and he would be filled with the Holy Ghost even before his birth. He would go before the Lord "in the spirit and power of Elias" and "make ready a people prepared for the Lord." John's story shows us what it means to serve Him. Before

John was born, he was given a responsibility: help people recognize and be ready to receive the One who was coming.

Zacharias would have heard a familiar promise in the angel's words. Malachi had prophesied that Elijah would come to turn the hearts of the fathers to the children. Now the angel was describing his own son with those words. A promise Zacharias knew from scripture was becoming part of his family's life. Yet he struggled to believe it could happen. He asked how he could know, since he and Elisabeth were old. The angel answered, "I am Gabriel, that stand in the presence of God." Apparently, Zacharias would need something more convincing than an angel appearing in the temple and speaking to him. Because Zacharias had not believed, he would be unable to speak until the promise was fulfilled.

At the close of the incense service, the priests would bless the people with the words the Lord gave Aaron: "The Lord bless thee, and keep thee." Outside, the people were waiting for a blessing, but Zacharias could not give it. He could only make signs. The people understood that he had seen a vision but could not speak the blessing. The scene here connects to the end of Luke's Gospel which closes with Jesus lifting His hands and blessing His disciples. The Lord whose blessing could not be spoken here would come among His people Himself.

It is easy to judge Zacharias for doubting, but a hope carried for years can become difficult to imagine coming true. His silence was a correction, and he had to wait while God did what He had promised. While he waited in silence, Elisabeth began to see the promise fulfilled. She described her experience by saying, "Thus hath the Lord dealt with me." Other people had seen her childlessness as a reason to judge her. The Lord knew her and had a work for her family to do.

Elisabeth also recognized the Lord when He came to her in an unexpected way. Her young cousin Mary visited while carrying her own promised child, and John leaped in Elisabeth's womb. Filled with the Holy Ghost, Elisabeth asked, "Whence is this to me, that the mother of my Lord should come to me?" Mary was her relative, but the child Mary carried was her Lord. John was already responding to the One he would spend his life serving.

When John was born, his parents followed the instruction they had been given about his name. The neighbors expected him to be named Zacharias after his father. Elisabeth said, "Not so; but he shall be called John." Zacharias asked for a writing tablet and wrote, "His name is John." At that moment, he could speak again, and he began to praise God. His earlier question had been how he could know the promise was true. Now he held the answer in his arms.

The family's names echo the promise God delivered to them. Zacharias means "the Lord remembers." Elisabeth means "God is an oath," and John means "the Lord is gracious." In his prophecy, Zacharias spoke of God remembering "his holy covenant; the oath which he [swore]." The Lord had remembered His people, kept His promise, and shown mercy to this family.

Even while celebrating his son's birth, Zacharias spoke first about the Savior his son would serve. He praised God for raising up salvation "in the house of his servant David." John belonged to Aaron's family, so Zacharias was speaking about the child Mary carried. Then he turned to his own son: "And thou, child, shalt be called the prophet of the Highest: for thou shalt go before the face of the Lord to prepare his ways." He described the coming Savior as "the dayspring from on high," coming "to give light to them that sit in darkness." Dayspring means dawn. John would prepare people for the Son's light.

Zacharias's responsibility to his son would eventually cost him his life. When the wise men asked Herod about the newborn King of the Jews, Herod saw a rival and ordered the young boys in and around Bethlehem killed. The Prophet Joseph Smith taught that John, about six months older than Jesus, also came under Herod's order. According to his teaching, Zacharias sent Elisabeth and John into the mountains to protect them. When Zacharias refused to reveal where his son was hiding, Herod had him killed "between the porch and the altar" of the temple. Joseph Smith identified him as the Zacharias whose death Jesus later spoke of in the temple. The father who had struggled to believe the promise gave his life to protect the son God had entrusted to him.

Years later, Jesus described John's ministry using an image that echoes Zacharias's prophecy. John spent his life helping people find their way to the

Lord, and many came to hear him. Jesus called John "a burning and shining lamp," in the English Standard Version's words. A lamp gives real light to people trying to find their way in the dark. John had done that for them. But Jesus also said of Himself, "I am the light of the world."

Zacharias spoke of the coming dawn, and John was a lamp that helped people see until it arrived. John's work was to lead people to the Lord. He could teach, testify, and prepare them, but Jesus was the One they needed to follow. I want what I say and do to help someone recognize the Lord.

[The speaker continues with his own testimony.]

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The script ends here. The speaker's own testimony follows.